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Nearly $50 Million in Security Funding Awarded to Nonprofits at Risk of Hate-Motivated Violence

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The California Office of Emergency Services has awarded nearly $50 million to nonprofit organizations across the state through the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program, the California Legislative Jewish Caucus announced on January 24.

The Jewish Caucus is hopeful that the funding, in response to the January 15 hostage standoff at Congregation Beth Israel in Colleyville, Texas, will make a substantial difference in protecting vulnerable communities across California.

"The recent hostage situation at Congregation Beth Israel was a sad and shameful example of the very real threats facing our community."

– Jesse Gabriel and Scott Weiner

"The recent hostage situation at Congregation Beth Israel was a sad and shameful example of the very real threats facing our community, and a further reminder of how security training and enhancements can mean the difference between life and death," said Jewish Caucus Chair, Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills) and Vice Chair, Senator Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco), in a joint statement.

Rabbi Charlie Cytron-Walker from Congregation Beth Israel highlighted the security training he received from local and national organizations as what helped save his life and the lives of three other hostages.

"Colleyville, Texas may be thousands of miles away, but the hostage situation at Congregation Beth Israel was deeply personal for many Jews in California," said Gabriel. "Our Caucus is committed to ensuring that the State of California steps up to protect our community and all other vulnerable communities targeted by hate."

Wiener told the Journal that the Jewish Caucus has worked for years to expand funding for the nonprofit security grant program, which allocates funding for community institutions, like synagogues, to protect themselves.

"The Texas synagogue hostage-taking shows once again why we fight so hard for this program," he said. "Antisemitism is a stain on our society, and we need to eradicate it. We also must ensure our community is safe from violent attacks and has the protection it needs to go about our daily lives. No one should feel scared simply because they are Jewish or in a Jewish space."

Officially established in 2019 through legislation authored by Gabriel and members of the Jewish Caucus, the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program was passed following the deadly shooting at Chabad of Poway in San Diego County. The program has funded critical security enhancements at religious institutions, LGBTQ community centers, reproductive health facilities and other nonprofits at risk for violence.

Last year's state budget included a $50 million allocation for the program, a historic increase that was secured with the support of leaders and activists representing a broad coalition of vulnerable communities. In 2019, the budget included $15 million for the program.

On January 19, the Jewish Caucus introduced AB 1664, which will extend and strengthen the program, currently set to expire in 2025. Authored by Gabriel, co-authors of the measure include Wiener, as well as Assemblymembers Rebecca Bauer-Kahan (D-Orinda), Marc Berman (D-Menlo Park), Richard Bloom (D-Santa Monica), Laura Friedman

(D-Glendale), Marc Levine (D–Marin County), Jose Medina (D-Riverside) and Chris Ward (D-San Diego), and state senators Ben Allen (D-Santa Monica), Josh Becker (D-Peninsula), Steve Glazer (D-Contra Costa), Bob Hertzberg (D-Van Nuys), Josh Newman (D-Orange County) and Henry Stern (D-Los Angeles).

In addition to extending the Nonprofit Security Grant Program, the legislation also will create more flexibility for how grant funding may be used.

Securing additional funding for the program continues to be a top priority for the Jewish Caucus, whose mission is to be a Jewish voice for justice, equality and progress. The 18 members work together to advance the Jewish community's top priorities, while uplifting vulnerable Californians of all backgrounds. It focuses on promoting the educational, social, legislative, professional and cultural interests of its members.

Gabriel and Wiener said, "We are committed to working with our legislative colleagues and community advocates to expand and strengthen the Nonprofit Security Grant Program."

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